



Deki bonsai

of the word 'workaholic' but prefers being called someone who follows his work religiously.

"I was spending 14 to 16 hours of my daily life at the hotels I was working with. I was ambitious and I think being that paid off. I simply loved and continue to love working," exclaims Sharma.

"However, one should never rule out the fact that you will be where your destiny wants you to be," Sharma adds. Being asthmatic, he was told by the doctors to take a break from the city of Bangalore (now Bengaluru). He adds, "I am asthmatic and Bangalore was not suiting me at all. Doctors told me to take a break."

Once, when his father-in-law visited Sharma's Bangalore house, during a regular family conversation he told Sharma about the liberalisation policy the government of India was introducing. His father-in-law said he had two choices: Either shutting down or selling the operations of Deki Electronics, or making the brand compete on global level with the global giants in capacitor manufacturing. The liberalisation message was clear, that there was no use sailing the global waters anywhere with a small boat.

Had no idea what a capacitor looked like

Sharma took the offer of working with his father-in-law seriously and the news of him quitting the hotel industry was a big surprise for everyone. But before he would say yes to working for Deki Electronics, he engaged in a conversation with one of the general managers at BPL Electronics. He knew this GM because of the hotel industry.

"I asked him about the offer from Deki Electronics and told him I am not

sure what I will do there. But before I say yes to them, I would like to know from you about what you feel of Deki Electronics," narrates Sharma. It is to be noted here that BPL Electronics was one of the customers of Deki Electronics back then.

Though the GM said he was pretty satisfied and happy doing business with Deki Electronics, Sharma wanted to speak to a Deki Electronics' customer who was not happy with the services, before saying yes to the offer of working with the capacitors making firm.

"I got to know of a purchase officer from BPL dealing with Deki Electronics who was not satisfied about the same. His major complaint included his company not getting capacitors in time. His company was into manufacturing TVs and a TV usually required 32 capacitors to be manufactured completely. His complaint was simple, that Deki Electronics would supply 28 capacitors for a TV and hold the order for the rest four," explains Sharma.

He further noted that when this purchase manager would call the company to check the status of rest of the capacitors, people at Deki Electronics would in turn inquire about the payment for the first 28 that were already shipped. Sharma then went back to the GM at BPL and asked him what made him happy about Deki Electronics. The GM answered that out of the three companies that manufactured capacitors in India at that time, Deki Electronics was the best.

"Whether good or bad news, out of the three companies we deal with, yours is the best," were this GM's exact words, says Sharma. This is where he saw a big opportunity. Remembering what he had learnt in his hotel management degree and experience working at a hotel, he said, "I have been operating on just one principle and that principle is that the

guest, or in this case the customer, is always right."

"If you serve soup in a hotel and the customer says that the soup is not hot, you do not get into an argument with the customer but instead bring him a good hot soup. That's the background I came from. But here in this industry, everyone followed a different approach. If you were to serve in this industry and the customer would complain about the soup being not hot, someone would probably shove a thermometer in the soup and tell the customer that the specifications say 70 degrees ($\pm$ two degrees) and this soup is currently at 68 degrees. So, you should be happy at what it is," explains Sharma about the difference between the two industries.

This was where Sharma realised that there was a huge scope for him joining the Deki Electronics team and saying goodbye to the hotel industry. He was, and is, of firm view that what he learned from his father and from the hotel industry experience would prove to be a milestone in the journey he was embarking upon.

But Sharma has not left behind his days in the hotel industry. He still organises barbecue parties for his staff and cooks himself. Referring to himself as a chef, he enjoys cooking as much as he relishes Korean and Italian cuisines.

Not a big fan of fiction

Not a big fan of fiction, his favourite cartoon series from his childhood days happens to be Asterix. He was so fond of this series that he wanted to start a cartoon series of his own to compete with Asterix. Though he was not able to start sketching on such a big scale, he has written a book which is famous amongst a lot of entrepreneurs. Titled 'ValueMagics,' this book, as Sharma explains, is written from a practical point of view for the entrepreneurs in developing countries who are planning to venture into foreign markets.

Recalling his childhood days and habits that have helped him secure a successful life, he mentions about the habit of reading newspaper every day that was instilled in him by his father. He was in the third standard when he got introduced to reading newspaper every day. His father had an interest-

THERE IS AT LEAST
A LOOSE PLAN
FOR YOU WHICH
GOD OR NATURE
MAKES FOR YOU.